

FX Daily: Risk on weighs on dollar, but caution warranted

Strong gains in risk assets around the globe are putting pressure on the dollar. We are not big fans of chasing it lower just yet, though. US interest rates are stable rather than falling, and there is little evidence so far of foreigners selling long-term US assets or increasing dollar hedge ratios. For today, look out for ECB speakers and minutes



Barring some negative headlines out of the Middle East, risk assets should stay mildly bid and the dollar mildly offered today

➔ USD: Case for a much weaker dollar has yet to be made

Risk assets are recovering well as investors continue to position for de-escalation in the Middle East. The return to equity markets and to pro-growth and higher-yielding EM currencies has led to a broadly softer dollar. However, we question whether conditions are right for a sustained dollar decline just yet, when assessing factors like Fed policy, global growth and any evidence that foreign investors are quietly leaving US asset markets or increasing dollar hedge ratios.

On the Fed, last night saw the release of the [Beige Book](#) ahead of the 29 April FOMC meeting. This showed economic activity flat to modestly expanding, with the K-shaped dynamic in full swing. Lower-income households were feeling the strain, while higher-income spending remained resilient. The labour market seemed to be holding up well, while on pricing, the survey showed that input costs were rising more quickly than selling prices. This was generating margin compression.

In all, it points to a Fed comfortable with the policy rate at 3.75%, where neither the labour market is deteriorating nor are second-round inflation effects growing. The case for renewed Fed easing has yet to be made, although the whole world will be glued to Kevin Warsh's confirmation hearing next Tuesday for any dovish plans.

On the subject of global growth, it is tough to see markets overlooking the headwinds which have been created over the last month. Energy prices look higher on a sustained basis (though this is not as large a shock as 2022), while interest rates, unlike currencies, have notably failed to retrace any of their moves in March. These tighter financial conditions have to prove a brake on global growth, which will likely emerge in hard data over the coming months.

As to the subject of volatile policymaking out of Washington causing investors to reduce concentration risk in US asset markets or increase dollar hedge ratios, evidence is scant. Last night's release of US TIC data for February showed the foreign private sector buying \$147bn of US long-term securities in February, the highest since last September. Equally, we have an article [here](#) suggesting that instead of causing the dollar sell-off during January/February's Venezuela/Greenland news, the European buy-side used the cheaper dollar to decrease their dollar hedge ratios.

Barring some negative headlines out of the Middle East, risk assets should stay mildly bid and the dollar mildly offered today, but we don't see conditions in place for DXY to make an immediate return to the lows of the year at 96. We have a couple of Fed speakers today and the weekly initial claims data, though these look unlikely to move markets.

Chris Turner

➔ EUR: ECB keeping its options open

EUR/USD price action has been impressive in that it has retraced the entirety of its losses in March. The good news for EUR/USD bulls is that the pricing of an April ECB hike has quietly evaporated without weighing too heavily on the euro. A June hike remains fully priced and we suspect the ECB will need to deliver this for EUR/USD to stay supported this summer.

Today, we will receive the minutes of the 19 March ECB meeting and then hear from a host of ECB speakers in Washington. The prevailing view at present is that the ECB sees the current situation somewhere between its baseline and adverse scenario, meaning that it has to keep the possibility of a rate hike on the table.

We have been surprised by how quickly EUR/USD has made it all the way back to 1.18. We are not fans of chasing it higher from here and feel it could easily correct back to 1.1700 on any adverse news.

Chris Turner

➔ JPY: Bold action threatened, but not a game-changer

US and Japanese currency officials have been meeting in Washington and suggestions of closer co-operation are keeping investors wary of intervention. Yet barring a big drop in energy prices from here (unlikely) or much lower US interest rates (again not clear), it looks like the verbal intervention from the Japanese is an exercise in containing USD/JPY upside.

However, at ING, we think the current probability (20%) of a Bank of Japan rate hike on 28 April is too low. Should it be delivered, that could help cement the top of the USD/JPY range at 160. But the conditions for a sustained drop in USD/JPY have yet to be met and we favour a continued 155-160 range for the rest of the quarter.

Chris Turner

BRL: The real has had a good crisis

If FX volatility starts to settle again, investors will increasingly return to the carry trade. Here, the Brazilian real, with its 12-13% per annum implied yields available through the NDF market, will remain popular. Brazil is also a net energy exporter and the prospect of a sustained easing cycle (175bp of cuts currently priced over the next 12 months) will keep the interest in Brazilian local currency bonds.

The real has also been benefiting from opinion polls showing that Flavio Bolsonaro would defeat President Lula in a second round run-off. Presidential elections take place in October this year. The Brazilian real does not look particularly expensive on a real, trade-weighted basis, and USD/BRL could continue its strong run sub-5.00 should global conditions allow.

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Rates Spark: Bear steepening impulses as sentiment holds up

Central bank pricing remains less hawkish compared to the start of the week, with the ECB sending more signals that a hike in April looks unlikely. But longer yields still see increases as risk sentiment continues to recover and primary markets see more activity again



Despite market risk sentiment looking optimistic, long-end rates rose more in the last trading session, resulting in a bear steepening

Recovering risk sentiment opens door to busy primary market

Market risk sentiment is looking more optimistic at the latest developments around the Strait of Hormuz. While oil prices remain elevated, they are holding at least below the US\$100/bbl mark this week. US equities have continued to rise and hit new all-time highs while credit spreads tightened.

Central bank pricing is also looking less hawkish compared to the start of the week. The ECB, for instance, provided more hints that a hike in April is unlikely, though not off the table – some 6bp is what the market is now pricing for the meeting. However, over the past session, we have seen long-end rates rise more, resulting in a bit of bear steepening this time around. Perhaps one should not read too much into it. After all, 10y UST yields had just touched the 4.24% mark again, a level last seen almost a month ago, which itself might argue for a little rebound. And a rise in yields also gels with risk assets performing better.

Relatively speaking, Bund yields do look more elevated at 3%, but given a busier primary market and little other domestic impetus following the general direction, higher looked like the path of least resistance. But the clearest sign that sentiment has also been improving in bond markets was

primary markets.

On the EUR side, there has also been a flurry of syndicated deals this week, kicked off by a (scheduled) dual tranche syndication from the EU on Tuesday, and France followed suit with a new green bond of its own. Yesterday, Italy sold a new 10y benchmark alongside a new 20y linker, and in the broader SSA space, Germany's NRW Bank and Land Berlin were in the market, while Canada's Quebec then mandated a 15y €-bond.

Thursday's events and market view

Following UK GDP and industrial production data in the morning, the main data points to watch will come from the US. The weekly jobless claims release will be watched more closely, with the market anticipating a small drop after initial claims had jumped to the highest since early February. The other indicators to watch are the industrial production for March and the Philadelphia Fed business Index for April. The eurozone will release final CPI data for March.

The focus these days remains on commentary from central bank officials ahead of the IMF spring meetings in Washington. From the ECB, Schnabel, an influential hawk, and Lane, as the bank's chief economist, will likely draw the most attention. Fed speakers scheduled are Williams and Miran, while Taylor will be speaking for the BoE. Note that the ECB will also publish the minutes of the 19 March policy-setting meeting.

Government bond primary markets will see scheduled auctions from Spain and France. Spain sells up to €6bn in 5y to 15y bonds, France up to €13bn in 3y to 7y bonds and another €2bn in inflation-linked bonds.

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China's GDP beats expectations amid intensifying global headwinds

China produced a solid first-quarter GDP read, as strong tertiary industry growth and solid industrial activity helped offset still sluggish consumption and investment and a drop in the first-quarter trade surplus. Higher energy prices could begin to drag on growth in the months ahead



China's robust trade performance has sparked fresh interest in the renminbi

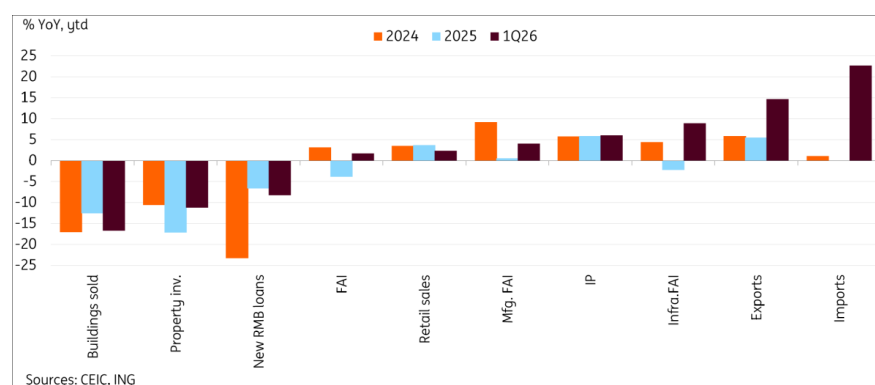
5.0% YoY

 China's 1Q26 GDP

Higher than expected

External demand continues to be a key growth driver for growth

But rising import costs could start to cut into growth



China's GDP started 2026 off strong

China's GDP came in at 5.0% year-on-year in the first quarter, beating the market and our expectations for a more modest start to the year. This 5.0% level was in line with the 2025 full-year growth and the fastest since the second quarter of 2025.

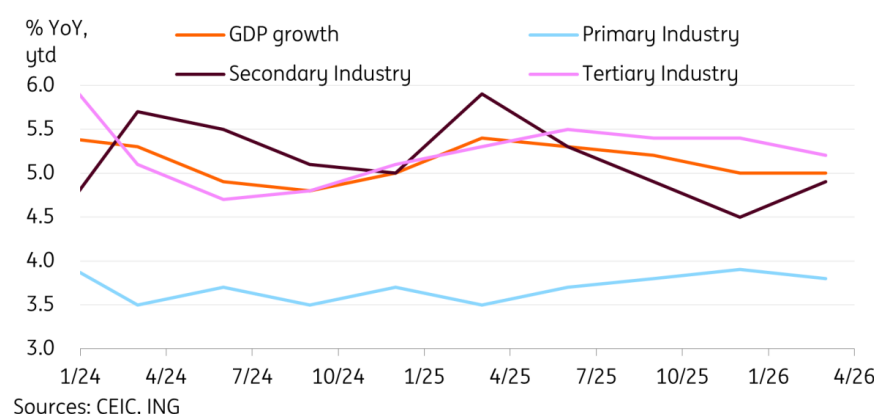
The services sector gets the credit for this outperformance. China's tertiary industry grew 5.2% YoY in 1Q26, outpacing the 4.9% growth in the secondary industry and the 3.8% growth in the primary industry. Households rebalancing spending from goods to services could be a factor in why growth beat expectations despite the slowdown of retail sales.

The breakdown of the GDP data will make for interesting reading when more details are available in a few days. We just saw [China's 1Q26 trade surplus fall in YoY terms](#). There are also growing signs of reflation, which should be weighing on the GDP deflator. March's data show stronger-than-expected industrial activity but disappointing investment and consumption, suggesting that domestic activity remains sluggish.

It's likely that 1Q26 growth is mostly insulated from the negative impact of the Iran war. China is well-placed to weather short-term disruptions, but could face more pressure if energy prices remain higher for longer. We could see a greater impact of higher prices on import costs and input costs in the months ahead.

However, for now, this above-expectation growth at the start of the year is positive news for China's growth, helping it achieve this year's growth target of 4.5-5.0%. It gives policymakers some buffer to work with and potentially reducing the urgency to ramp up more aggressive stimulus.

Tertiary industry continued to outperform in 1Q26



Industrial activity remains bright spot in China's domestic activity data

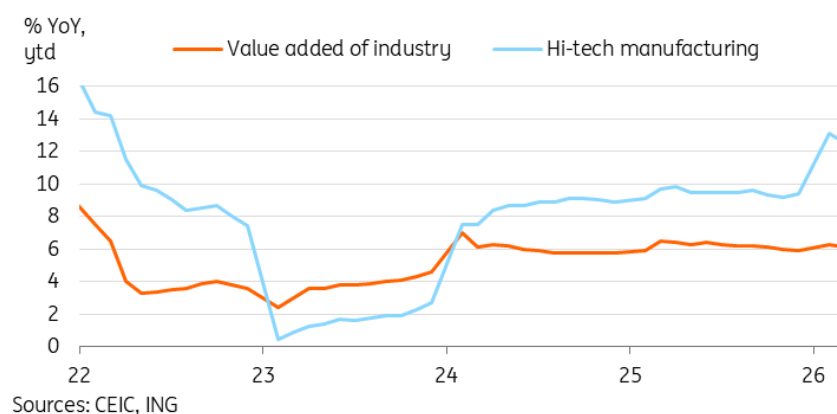
Value added of industry rose 5.7% YoY in March, down from the 6.3% YoY ytd level in the first two months of the year, but still stronger than market consensus and our slightly more optimistic forecast. Through the first quarter of 2026, value added of industry has grown 6.1% YoY ytd, a clear outperformer in China's domestic activity indicators.

Strong external demand continues to support China's industrial activity. The areas with the fastest-growing exports also saw the strongest industrial production growth, such as rail, ships, and aeroplanes (13.3%), computer, communication, and electronic equipment (12.5%), autos (7.5%), and semiconductors (20.6%).

China's robotics industry continues to see solid growth, with production of industrial robots (24.4%) and service robots (6.7%) both surpassing the headline growth.

China's increasing hi-tech manufacturing (11.7%) competitiveness is likely to be one of the core pillars of growth in the coming years.

Hi-tech manufacturing continues to comfortably outpace overall industrial activity



Retail sales growth sliding as trade-in policy effects offset decent performance elsewhere

Retail sales, on the other hand, missed expectations, coming in at just 1.7% YoY in March, after a 2.8% YoY ytd start in the first two months of the year. Through the first quarter of 2026, retail sales have grown just 2.4% YoY ytd.

We've written many times about the fading impact of China's trade-in policy and how it was gradually turning from a tailwind to a headwind in the data. We're seeing this play out very clearly in the data.

Looking at the key beneficiary categories of China's trade-in policy, we saw household appliance sales drop by -5.0% YoY in March, lowering 1Q26 growth to 0.0% YoY, after year-on-year growth of over 30% for multiple months last year.

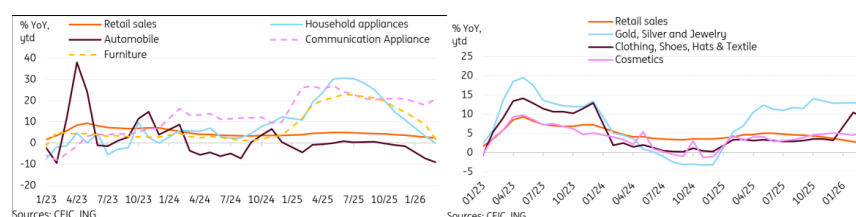
Similarly, furniture sales fell -8.7% YoY in March, bringing 1Q26 growth to a paltry 1.9% YoY ytd, after growing in excess of 20% for multiple months last year.

Auto sales remained sluggish, down -11.8% YoY in March and -9.1% YoY ytd in 1Q26. The trade-in policy and other preferential policies for EVs had been instrumental in China's rapid adoption. But it looks like this is plateauing and should enter a more mature supply-and-demand cycle ahead.

The last key subcategory yet to show signs of a notable slowdown is the communication appliance category. It continues to see robust YoY growth of 27.3% in March, boosting 1Q26 growth to 20.8% YoY. If this softens, we could see further pressure on retail sales data ahead.

The drag from the trade-in policy categories offsets the actual decent growth in other categories. Discretionary spending categories such as gold and jewellery (11.7%), cosmetics (8.3%), and garments (7.7%) all performed well in March. Staples such as grain, oil, and other food (9.5%), beverages (8.2%), and tobacco and liquor (7.7%) all saw much stronger growth than headline growth.

Drag from last year's outperformers is overshadowing decent sales growth elsewhere



Fixed asset investment softened in March

Fixed asset investment growth edged down slightly to 1.7% YoY ytd, down from 1.8% YoY ytd in the first two months of the year, weaker than expectations for a slight acceleration.

The data continues to suggest that the government is following through on its intention to stabilise investment. Public-led investment rose 7.1% YoY ytd, while private sector caution persists, with private enterprise investment down -2.2% YoY ytd. Manufacturing FAI came in decently at 4.1%

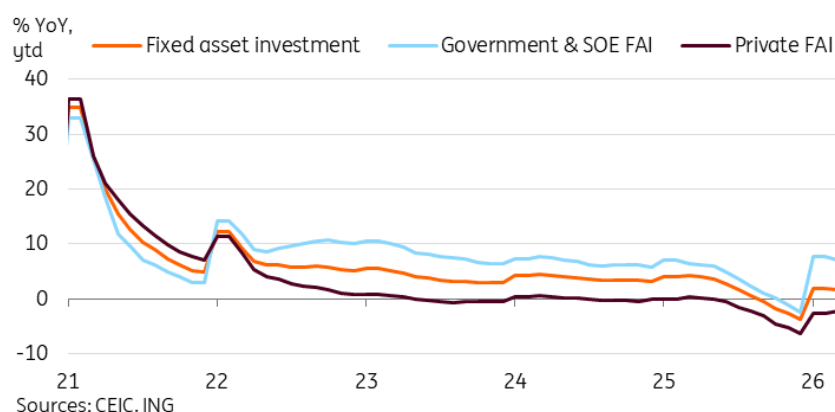
YoY ytd, while infrastructure FAI outperformed with a 8.9% YoY ytd growth in 1Q26.

While overall investment growth remains sluggish, certain industries continue to see strong investment. The rail, ships, and aeroplane industry saw 27.7% YoY ytd growth, while the logistics industry saw 16.3% YoY ytd growth as well. We also saw solid investment growth in the agricultural (15.2%), mining (15.0%), and textiles (17.6%) industries.

The larger drag on investment came from the usual culprit: real estate FAI, which was down -11.2% YoY ytd. The tertiary sector, too, where FAI into education (-7.9%), healthcare (-9.7%), and culture, sport, and entertainment (-5.4%) were deep in negative territory again after performing poorly in 2025.

While it's encouraging to see FAI growth back in positive territory after 2025 marked the first recorded annual decline, the 1.7% YoY ytd pace suggests investment is unlikely to be a major growth driver this year.

Strong public sector led investment suggests early efforts to stabilise investment growth



Property prices continued to drop but at slowest pace since 1Q25

The National Bureau of Statistics published its 70-city sample of housing prices. New home prices fell by -0.21% month-on-month, while used home prices fell by -0.24% MoM in March. While prices continued to fall, we began to see more divergence in the city-level data, and overall, the pace of contraction was the smallest since 1Q25.

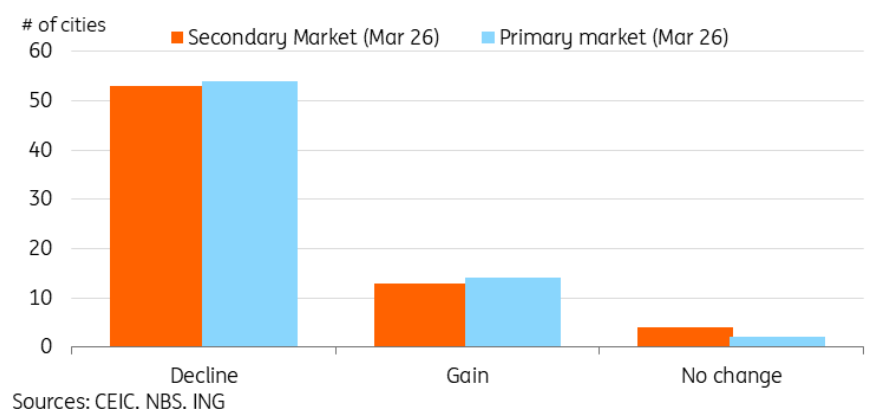
Looking at the city-level data, for the primary market, 16 cities saw prices stabilise or increase in March, down slightly from 17 in February. In the secondary market, we saw 17 cities with stable or higher prices, marking the highest proportion since 2023, including a 0.6% MoM price pickup in Beijing. This is an encouraging development, as secondary market prices will have a bigger impact on household confidence.

While continued price declines can't be characterised as good news, there does appear to be at least some momentum toward stabilisation again.

We continue to await signs of confirmation of a trough forming. Structural overcapacity remains a

consideration for lower-tier cities. But stabilisation of prices in tier 1 and 2 cities would be a significant step in China's efforts to pivot toward domestic demand-driven growth.

Property prices continued to fall but more cities saw rising or stable prices



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The Commodities Feed: Oil trades lower on de-escalation hopes

Oil prices continue to move lower amid signals that a ceasefire between the US and Iran will be extended



Energy- US oil exports jump to record levels

The oil market continues to edge lower amid hopes that the US and Iran extend their ceasefire by another 2 weeks, along with a potential resumption in talks to bring an end to the war. However, the physical market is becoming tighter every day that passes without a restart of oil flows through the Strait of Hormuz. After taking into consideration pipeline diversions and the trickle of tankers through the Strait of Hormuz, we estimate that roughly 13m b/d has been disrupted. But with the US blockade, this number could creep higher. The divergence between the futures and physical markets is clear: dated Brent traded around \$117/bbl, while front-month Brent futures settled a little below \$95/bbl yesterday. The key upside risk for the market is that peace talks between the US and Iran break down. This isn't an unrealistic scenario, given that US and Iranian demands remain fairly wide apart.

The latest data from the Energy Information Administration (EIA) shows that US crude oil exports jumped by 1.08m b/d week-on-week to 5.23m b/d- the highest volume since September 2025. However, total oil and refined product exports surged by 1.03 m b/d WoW, hitting a record 12.74 m b/d. These stronger US exports reflect buyers turning to other markets for supply amid disruptions

in the Middle East. Despite strong exports, US crude oil inventories declined only marginally over the week, falling by 913k barrels. Refined product stocks saw more meaningful declines, with gasoline and distillate inventories falling by 6.33m barrels and 3.12m barrels, respectively.

With buyers shifting toward US barrels, the domestic market is set to tighten as long as Middle East disruptions persist, likely prompting a supply response from US producers. US drilling activity, however, has barely moved since the start of the conflict. According to Baker Hughes data the US oil rig count stood at 411 last week, up from 407 prior to the war. The lack of drilling activity also ties in with the EIA's domestic crude oil production forecasts, which suggest little change in output this year. If we see a pickup in US drilling activity, it would have a more meaningful impact on oil output over 2027.

European gas prices continue to edge lower amid hopes of de-escalation in the Middle East, while EU gas storage levels move closer to 30% full as the region moves deeper into the injection season. High LNG send-outs in Europe have kept the market comfortable. Investment funds also reduced their net long in TTF by 37.4 TWh over the last week to 271.8 TWh. Clearly, the longer disruptions in the Middle East persist, the more competition we'll see from Asia as buyers seek alternative supplies. JKM continues to trade at a premium to TTF, so we should be seeing cargoes being redirected towards Asia.

Metals – Copper trades near one month high on Iran optimism

Copper rose to around a one month high this week, with broader gains across industrial metals as markets priced in easing macro risks. Optimism that the US and Iran could restart talks helped unwind some of the recent pressure from fears of higher energy costs and weaker growth.

However, the market remains highly headline driven. Any escalation in the conflict, renewed spikes in energy prices or signs of softer demand could quickly reverse sentiment. In a de escalation scenario, copper would likely outperform, supported by expectations of eventual rate cuts, a weaker dollar and a broader improvement in risk appetite.

Downstream supply risks are also gaining attention. Sulfuric acid is emerging as a bottleneck for SX EW copper output, with around half of seaborne sulfur transiting the Strait of Hormuz. China's sulfuric acid prices have risen around 90% since the start of the Iran war. Export bans introduced following the Hormuz shipping halt are raising disruption risks to acid-dependent supply in Chile, Peru and the Democratic Republic of the Congo.

Positioning data points to improved sentiment. Speculators increased their bullish LME copper bets by 2,329 net long positions to 48,225, the most bullish stance in more than three months, according to weekly futures and options data.

In precious metals, gold remains supported amid renewed optimism around de escalation. The pullback in oil prices is easing some of the inflation concerns that weighed on prices earlier in the conflict. The move reflects a broader shift in market focus. While gold initially fell sharply as liquidity pressures forced selling, losses have since partially recovered as growth concerns have re emerged and price swings have become less extreme. While higher real rates, a firmer dollar, and profit-taking could weigh on near-term price action, recent pullbacks suggest underlying demand remains resilient.

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What next for Hungary as opposition beats Orbán by a landslide

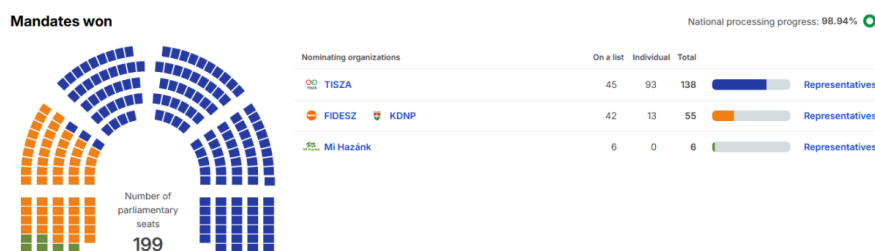
Following a record-high turnout, Hungarian voters handed power to the Tisza Party. This comfortable two-thirds majority victory paves the way for a smoother and faster political and economic transition. However, the country's economic structure and its dependencies will limit the short-term impact on the real economy



Peter Magyar addresses supporters after his party wins a landslide in Hungary's elections

The election results

Hungary delivered a clean political break. The Péter Magyar-led Tisza Party won a decisive, two thirds parliamentary majority on record-high turnout, ending Viktor Orbán's Fidesz party's 16 year dominance and securing full legislative control in a single vote. While the results are still not official, the most likely outcome is that Tisza won 138 of 199 seats. The three single-member constituencies are still in limbo due to the extremely tight race, and late votes from abroad can change the official outcome. However, none of the possible outcomes would jeopardise the supermajority. In this respect, the result signals not fragmentation but consolidation: voters coordinated around one credible challenger.



Source: valasztas.hu

What's next in politics?

Until the new government is formed, the Orbán administration is acting as a caretaker government. The new Parliament must be formed within 30 days after the election, so by 13 May. This date is important from another perspective. In Hungary, a special legal regime has been in effect continuously since May 25, 2022, as a result of the state of emergency declared due to the "armed conflict in a neighbouring country," namely the war in Ukraine. According to current legislation, this state of emergency will remain in effect until May 13, 2026 (parliament decided last October to extend the 180-day state of emergency once again). In other words, the President of the Republic must convene the inaugural session of the new National Assembly following the April 12 elections.

So, while a caretaker government's actions are limited due to the state of emergency, in theory, the Orbán administration remains in full power until the new government is formed. However, considering the election results, we doubt that the outgoing party will make any major decisions.

What's next in economic policies?

From a macro perspective, the key takeaway is the unexpected strength of the mandate for regime change, which reduces short-term policy uncertainty while raising expectations of institutional repair, EU relations and fiscal credibility more quickly than expected. We expect to see many positive headlines in the coming weeks, as Péter Magyar attempts to gain a head start in improving relations with neighbouring countries (such as those in the [Visegrad Group](#)) and with the European Union.

While there is widespread expectation that the Magyar government will quickly resolve the EU-fund-related issues, the reality is that it may take longer. Due to allegations of Hungarian spying on EU officials, trust in Hungarian institutions has fallen to a low point. To regain this trust, more than just symbolic measures are needed. In this respect, the RRF deadline could prove too tight, even with a supermajority.

The Hungarian budget is also facing pressure to be restructured, given that the macro backdrop on which it was based has changed significantly. So, first, the new government needs to come up with a new macro baseline that can serve as a credible building block for the reshaped budget. The new government also needs to reshape the economy, and while it can start work on that, a structural change can take more than one political term.

The new government also needs to decide on the price shield measures, which will remain in place until May. Time is of the essence, and in this respect, the most probable outcome would be an extension until the government has more clarity on the fiscal and economic situation. Speaking of fiscal, this year will probably be about dismantling the inherited budgetary and economic policy structure, which could lead to even worse fiscal metrics in the short term. However, the long-term

gains may be sufficient to persuade market players and rating agencies to allow the new government time to reshape the country. We think that the first 100 days will be seen as a grace period. Hence, in our view, the first round of sovereign rating decisions in late May and early June won't result in any change.

Last but not least, the government could set a target date for euro adoption, establishing a path to reach it, which can be shaped later. If timed perfectly, this could boost market confidence and give the Tisza party more time to work on the Hungarian economy with some tailwinds.

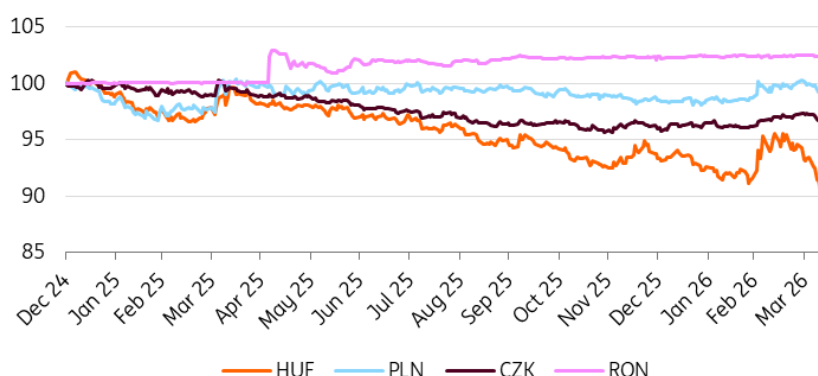
What about the HUF?

The scale of the opposition's win was a surprise. Although market positioning is difficult to read after the US-Iran conflict, the return of EUR/HUF to pre-conflict levels last week suggests that the market was pricing in a simple majority victory for the opposition.

From the market's perspective, the constitutional majority allows for a smooth transfer of power for the opposition and a faster path to unlocking EU funds, which are the main focus of investors, giving Hungarian assets another reason to extend their rally.

CEE FX performance vs EUR

31 Dec 2024 = 100%



Source: Macrobond

The situation in the Middle East significantly obscures the situation, with the expected market opening in a risk-off mood and pressure on the entire CEE region. However, if we were to assume some calm in this, we expect EUR/HUF to stabilise at levels of 355-360 and the bond and IRS curves to move down by about another 30-40bp in the coming days. In our view, the long end of the curve should benefit most from the result, with a better GDP outlook driven by the expected inflow of EU funds and, at the same time, the topic of euro adoption, which the opposition emphasised in its election campaign. On the other hand, the short end will remain burdened by the US-Iran conflict and higher energy prices, preventing the central bank from cutting rates in the coming months despite FX outperforming CEE peers. This will result in curve flattening.

However, another unknown and an increasingly volatile factor in the coming days will be the timing of profit-taking. Given the significant global uncertainty, investors are likely to want to

realise profits earlier than usual, which is likely to lead to higher volatility.

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Webinar: Energy security under strain - why cutting Europe's gas dependency won't be easy

Join our live webinar this Friday 17 April as ING's Gerben Hieminga and Nadège Tillier discuss how the conflict in the Middle East is once again exposing Europe's gas dependence and the hard choices that lie ahead. [Sign up here](#)



Against a backdrop of renewed conflict in the Middle East, markets are again grappling with energy security risks. Iran remains in control of the Strait of Hormuz, and Europe, despite the lessons of 2022, still imports around 70% of its gas. This raises a pressing question: how exposed is Europe if this crisis continues, and what can realistically be done about it?

[Join ING's experts as they discuss:](#)

- Europe's current level of dependence on imported gas
- The short term levers to ease supply risks
- Why longer term solutions – from renewables to nuclear – are harder than they look
- What business leaders should prioritise now

Speakers

Gerben Hieminga, Senior Sector Economist, Energy

Nadège Tillier, Head of Corporate Sector Strategy

Hosted by Rebecca Byrne, Deputy Global Head of Editorial

Details

Date: Friday, 17 April

Time: 1130 BST/1230 CEST

The webinar will last 30 minutes, including a Q&A session at the end. The event will take place online and the waiting room will open 60 minutes ahead of the scheduled start time. A joining link will be emailed following registration and you will receive a reminder email 10 minutes before the scheduled start time.

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THINK Ahead: Tell us what you really think

Markets are confidently pricing as many as three European Central Bank rate hikes this year, or so it seems. Our live poll this week suggests otherwise. Read on as James Smith weighs up the case for rate rises in April and June, and explains why it's a dilemma fraught with risk. All that, plus our guide to the week ahead



Are markets really expecting two ECB rate hikes this year?

[Watch video](#)

Do investors really think the European Central Bank is going to hike rates several times this year?

Take a look at the poll we ran during our [webinar](#) this week, conducted just 24 hours after the US Iran ceasefire announcement. The audience split almost perfectly three ways between zero, one and two hikes this year. Nobody could agree on what comes next.

And yet, if you glance at your Bloomberg screen, you'd be forgiven for thinking the answer is obvious. For weeks now, swap markets have been pricing between two and three hikes by year-end.

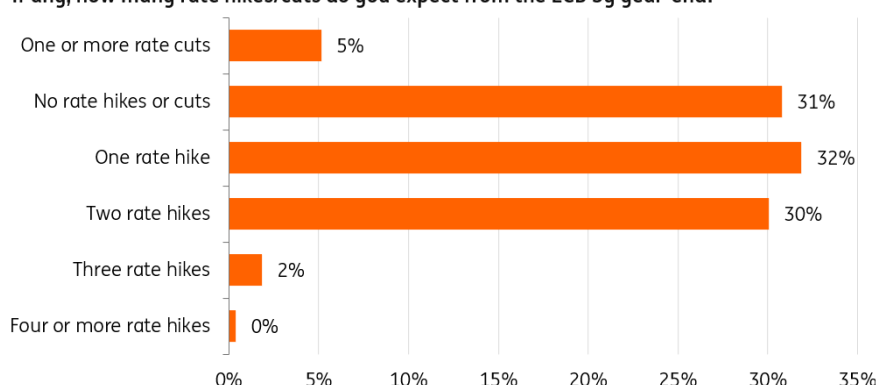
That disconnect suggests market pricing can't be taken entirely at face value. Liquidity is poor. As my colleague Michiel Tukker explains in the video above, thin markets can exaggerate the story. More importantly, market prices are not forecasts. They're weighted averages of multiple scenarios.

Those scenarios range from a relatively benign outcome through to a far more uncomfortable world in which oil prices surge and central banks are forced back into inflation fighting mode. Seeing two hikes on a screen and treating it as a point expectation is probably unwise.

Nobody can agree on what the ECB will do next

Webinar poll

If any, how many rate hikes/cuts do you expect from the ECB by year-end?



Source: ING

Based on a live poll of 273 webinar attendees on Thurs 9 April at 10:00 CEST

Still, the fact that markets are pricing *more than one* hike creates a genuine dilemma for the ECB, and, frankly, for lots of central banks.

Hiking rates now is risky. [This is not 2022](#). The odds of higher energy prices triggering a classic wage price spiral look much lower in today's economic climate. [Weak German industrial data](#) this week is just the latest reminder of that. As Carsten told our [webinar](#) audience, markets flirting with three or four hikes - something we've seen intermittently in recent weeks - would risk unnecessary strain in financial markets and put additional pressure on an already fragile eurozone recovery.

It's also worth remembering that this shock looks different from the last one. So far, it's much more an oil shock than an electricity shock. Natural gas prices, in the grand scheme of things, haven't moved that much, despite the sharp loss of LNG supply from the Gulf.

And yet, central banks are clearly uneasy. Having got inflation so spectacularly wrong four years ago, they're desperate not to repeat the mistake. Which brings us to inflation expectations - the thing policymakers fear losing control of most.

So far, market based measures of longer term inflation expectations haven't really budged since the conflict began. The five year inflation swap priced five years forward - a decent gauge of where investors think inflation ultimately settles - looks remarkably calm. But that calm is conditional. It assumes the ECB delivers multiple rate hikes this year. A similar logic is true of the Bank of England.

Fast-forward three weeks to the April policy meetings, and here's the issue: it's far from clear that

the situation in the Gulf will be any easier to read by then. Let's see what comes out of talks in Pakistan this weekend. But the tentative lesson from this week is that the backdrop is likely to remain fragile and vulnerable to re escalation on multiple fronts.

The Strait of Hormuz, in particular, is showing little sign of a clean or durable reopening. And even if flows improve over the coming days, it remains vulnerable to closure again at short notice.

In that environment, the temptation for policymakers – and probably the most likely outcome – is a re run of March. Keep rates on hold, stress the unusually high level of uncertainty, and keep all options firmly on the table. A handful of dissents in favour of rate hikes would probably help signal that inflation risks are being taken seriously. In other words: keep your powder dry, let investors (and the rate hikes priced in) do some of the tightening for them.

This strategy can only work for so long.

At some point, markets begin to wonder whether central banks are all bark and no bite. And that's when the risk shifts. If investors start to doubt the willingness of policymakers to follow through, inflation expectations – and by extension, the longer end of the bond market – risk becoming harder to control.

We've already seen consumer inflation expectations spike, don't forget. Personally, I'm not convinced that matters very much. Central banks may take a different view.

Then there's the length of the disruption itself. The longer volatility in Middle Eastern commodity flows persists, the more likely it is that we see broader supply chain effects creep in. Think of helium supplies critical for semiconductor production. Aluminium for cars. Fertiliser for food. The list goes on. And, crucially, visibility on how these effects interact is low. The Covid pandemic taught us that.

Which brings us to June.

Central banks can probably get away with a hold in April, blaming geopolitical uncertainty and a lack of economic data to guide them. By the summer, things get much more awkward. If commodity flows through the Middle East remain volatile and unpredictable, investors may begin to question the commitment of central bankers to keeping inflation under control.

The risk of second round effects on prices will have risen, and we might start to see the first hints of that in the official core inflation data. And remember, ECB policy is not especially restrictive to begin with. A 2% deposit rate is widely seen as neutral.

There are, of course, many ways the disruption in the Middle East could play out. We're updating our forecasts and scenarios as we speak – more from us on that next week. But put it this way, it becomes easier to imagine the ECB hiking rates in June if the disruption doesn't resolve much by then, particularly when you add in Germany's fiscal stimulus in the background. Carsten made exactly that point on this week's [webinar](#).

After all, what's one rate hike between friends? But it's a delicate balance. As the Bank of England learnt the hard way back in March, talking tough – even without actually hiking – can open the floodgates for markets to price in far more tightening than policymakers ever intended.

And in a fragile growth environment, that's a dangerous game to play.

James Smith

THINK Ahead in developed markets

United States (James Knightley)

- **Beige Book** (Wed): It is a fairly quiet week in the US next week with the US-Iran negotiations set to drive market sentiment. The data calendar consists of PPI and import prices, which are set to highlight the build up in pipeline price pressures initiated by the Middle East conflict. Industrial production will be the main activity release and based off the ISM manufacturing report and Federal Reserve regional surveys, we expect another decent performance. The Federal Reserve's Beige Book report is also worth watching. This is an anecdotal survey on the state of the US economy that is an important determinant of Fed policy directions. It is likely to highlight increased corporate caution, subdued hiring and rising inflation pressures.

THINK Ahead in Central and Eastern Europe

Poland (Adam Antoniak)

- **Feb BoP** (Mon): We estimate that the February current account recorded a €293mn surplus vs. €115mn in February last year. That translates into a 12-month cumulative deficit narrowing to 0.5% of GDP vs. 0.6% of GDP after February. According to our forecasts, exports of goods in euro-terms were at a similar level as the corresponding month of 2025, while imports fell by nearly 1% year-on-year. Starting from April, we may see some deterioration in the balance of payments on the back of more expensive imports of oil due to the military conflict in the Middle East. In 2026, we forecast a current account deficit of 1.4% of GDP.
- **Mar final CPI** (Wed): The flash estimate of March CPI of 3.0% YoY surprised on the positive side as the upswing in fuel prices was lower than feared (though might be revised upwards) and apart from petroleum, price pressures were benign. There were no significant changes in either food or housing energy prices vs. February. We also estimate that core inflation, excluding food and energy prices, was broadly unchanged and stood at 2.5-2.6% YoY. The official figure will be released on Thursday. So far, the energy shock is relatively contained and with a ceasefire announced, there is a chance it may remain a supply-side shock with limited spread to prices of other goods and services. We forecast average CPI inflation in Poland at 3.2% this year.

Czech Republic (David Havrlant)

- **Inflation** (Tue): We expect the statistical office to confirm that annual headline inflation remained just below the inflation target in March. The detailed breakdown and Czech National Bank calculation will likely show that annual core inflation remained broadly stable or slightly increased on the back of the punchier price dynamics in the service segment.
- **Current account** (Mon): The current account surplus likely increased in February, as the export performance was still intact before the Iran conflict, while imports for investment purposes somewhat mitigated the effect of solid exports.

Key events in developed markets next week

Country	Time Data/event	ING	Prev.
Monday 13 April			
US	1500 Mar Existing Home Sales (mn)	4	4.1
Netherlands	0530 Feb Trade Balance (EUR bn)	-	8.1
Tuesday 14 April			
US	1330 Mar PPI (MoM%/YoY%)	1,4/4,6	0.7/3.4
Sweden	0700 Mar CPI Final (MoM%/YoY%)	-/-	-0.6/0.6
	0700 Mar CPIF Final (MoM%/YoY%)	-/-	-0.6/1.6
Wednesday 15 April			
US	1900 Fed Beige Book	-	-
Eurozone	1000 Feb Industrial Production (MoM%/YoY%)	-/-	-1.5/-1.2
France	0745 Mar CPI Final (MoM%/YoY%)	-/-	0.9/1.7
Greece	1000 Mar CPI (YoY%)	-	2.7
Thursday 16 April			
US	1415 Mar Industrial Production (MoM%)	0.2	0.2
	1330 Initial Jobless Claims (000s)	215	219
Eurozone	1000 Mar CPI (YoY%) Final	-	2.5
UK	0700 Feb GDP Estimate (MoM%/YoY%)	0.2/0.6	0.0/0.8
Friday 17 April			
Eurozone	1000 Feb Current Account (EUR bn)	-	13
	1000 Feb Total Trade Balance (EUR bn)	-	-1.9
Italy	0900 Feb Global Trade Balance (EUR bn)	-	1.1

Source: Refinitiv, ING

Key events in EMEA next week

Country	Time (BST) Data/event	ING	Prev.
Monday 13 April			
Turkey	0800 Feb Current Account Balance (USD bn)	-7.1	-6.8
	0800 Feb Retail Sales (MoM%/YoY%)	-/-	2.4/18.8
Poland	1300 Feb Current Account (EUR bn)	0.3	1.2
Czech Rep	0900 Feb Current Account Balance (CZK bn)	34.2	29.2
Kazakhstan	- Mar Industrial Production (YoY%)	-	3.2
Tuesday 14 April			
Czech Rep	0800 Mar CPI (MoM%/YoY%)	0.6/1.9	0.6/1.9
Ukraine	0000 Oct Trade Balance YTD	-	-30.6
Romania	0800 Mar CPI (MoM%/YoY%)	-/-	0.6/9.3
Serbia	1100 Mar CPI (MoM%/YoY%)	-/-	0.5/2.5
Wednesday 15 April			
Turkey	0900 Mar Budget Balance (TRY bn)	-	24.4
Poland	0830 Mar CPI Final (MoM%/YoY%)	1/3	1/3
Romania	0700 Feb Industrial Production (MoM%/YoY%)	-/-	-3.3/-3.8
Thursday 16 April			
Poland	1300 Mar Core Inflation (YoY%)	2.5	2.5
Croatia	1000 Mar CPI Final (YoY%)	-	3.8
Friday 17 April			
Hungary	0730 Feb Average Gross Wages (YoY%)	8.8	26.3

Source: Refinitiv, ING

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US inflation much more likely to be transitory this time around

Gasoline price hikes prompted a jump in headline inflation, but core pressures were more benign than feared. We have much greater confidence that inflation will be transitory this time around, given the lack of demand impetus and weaker corporate pricing power versus 2022



US CPI for March rose on higher gasoline prices, but we do think higher inflation will be transitory

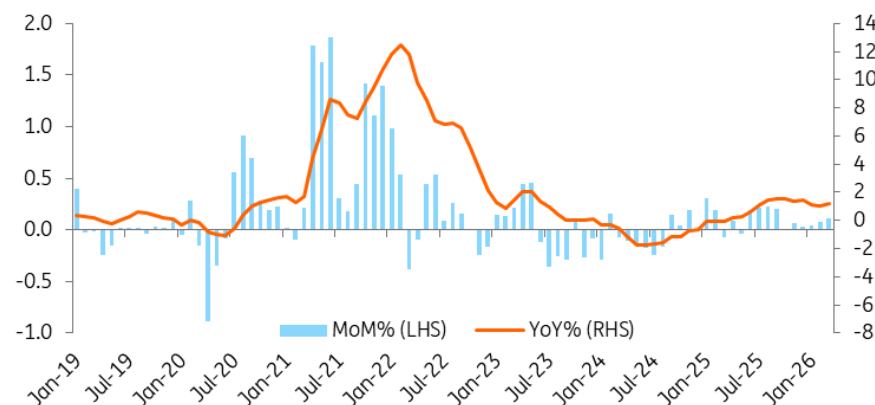
Gasoline prompts an inflation jump, but core pressures were softer than feared

US headline CPI showed prices rising 0.9% month-on-month in March, as expected by the market, with a 21.2% MoM jump in gasoline prices contributing the bulk of upside impetus. Airline fares rose 2.7% MoM and apparel prices rose 1%. However, excluding food and energy, inflation was softer than feared, rising only 0.2% MoM/2.6% YoY versus expectations of a 0.3%/2.7% outcome. This was thanks largely to a 0.4% drop in used car prices, a 0.2% decline in medical care and a 0.4% decline in "other goods & services". Housing costs, the single biggest component by weight, rose 0.3%.

The economy has handled tariffs well, with limited goods price inflation. Core goods prices (ex-food

and energy), remain benign, rising just 1.2% year-on-year. Instead, the tariff cost is largely being borne by the US corporate sector – next week's import prices will show another monthly rise, indicating foreign producers are not “paying” the tariffs.

Core goods price inflation



Source: Macrobond, ING

“Transitory” inflation far more likely this time

While the rise in energy costs will push the annual inflation rate even higher over the next few months, we don't expect a repeat of 2021/22 when the Fed called inflation pressures “transitory” only to then hike rates 525bp as inflation got within touching distance of 10%.

The supply shock this time around is arguably far smaller, focused in the US' case on gasoline and other fuel costs rather than *all goods* AND energy in the wake of pandemic-dislocated global supply chains. More importantly, there isn't the demand impetus this time around to generate broad and persistent inflation. 2022 saw 4.5mn jobs added, wage growth touching 6%, significant pent-up demand, record savings levels and stimulus checks. This time we have a much cooler jobs market with wage growth closer to 3%, weaker confidence and flat-lining real household disposable income.

Rising fuel costs likely to be demand destructive

Fuel price hikes are more likely to be demand destructive, via reduced discretionary spending power. This point was underlined by yesterday's personal income and spending report, which showed real household disposable incomes were flatlining before the Middle East conflict. We are likely to see this turning negative in coming months. Furthermore, if we see a successful outcome for the US-Iran negotiations and the flow of oil and gas starts to trickle out before coming more of a proper flow through the second half of the year, lower energy costs could possibly drive inflation below 2% at some point next year. As such, we still think interest rate cuts are more likely than hikes, especially given the Fed's dual mandate (price stability AND Maximum employment).

What would change our Fed view? If inflation expectations were to start rising and wage demands pick up, but right now both market and consumer long-term inflation expectations appear anchored and there continues to be more unemployed Americans than there are job vacancies – remember back in 2022 there were two job vacancies to every unemployed American. This highlights how the demand-supply balance has shifted within the jobs market and explains why we think second-round price effects will be far more muted this time relative to the post-pandemic

inflation shock.

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Watch: How the energy shock is hammering Europe's construction industry

Europe's construction industry finds itself at the mercy of the sharp rises in oil and gas prices we've seen since the start of the war in the Middle East. ING's Maurice van Sante says we're seeing the strongest price rise expectations since the 2022 energy crisis.

There's more on Maurice's findings [here](#)



How the energy shock is hammering the construction industry

Oil and gas prices may have come down since the apparent ceasefire in the Middle East, but still-elevated levels are really bad news for Europe's construction industry. Materials such as cement, concrete, and bricks are highly energy-intensive to produce. We're already seeing that pressure add up; nearly a fifth of European building manufacturers said last month they would increase their prices. That's the highest reading in three years. Some countries are more exposed than others, notably the Netherlands and Spain, where producers are more reliant on gas. And all this comes at a time when the construction industry was just seeing a turnaround in its fortunes.

[Watch video](#)

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How Europe can reduce reliance on imported gas and what it means for business leaders

As Europe confronts a new energy crisis, we explore key measures to strengthen energy security beyond simply lowering energy bills, and the potential implications for business leaders



Europe still imports about 70% of its gas, leaving it exposed to supply risks

The EU has several levers it can pull to reduce its exposure to volatile gas markets if the energy crisis were to intensify.

Lowering gas demand is possible, but it comes with significant challenges and sacrifices. For households, further reductions are limited as thermostats are already turned down in the spring and summer – meaning that actions like shorter, less frequent showers may be necessary. In industry, decreased gas consumption is often the result of closures and deindustrialisation, rather than improved efficiency. In the short term, maximising the output of existing **hydro, nuclear, and coal power** plants offers the most immediate relief for the power sector.

While **renewables** surged after the 2022 energy crisis, current grid constraints limit their ability to provide a rapid solution. Over the medium term, expanding **biogas** production presents meaningful potential. Although **offshore gas production** is naturally declining, there is still an opportunity to extend the use of remaining resources and tap into new fields. This renewed crisis is likely to accelerate efforts to revive the **nuclear** sector, but such projects require many years to

come to fruition. Unlike the energy crisis of the 1970s, which led to France's nuclear expansion, today, renewables are set to become the foundation of Europe's future energy systems.

As a **business leader**, immediate actions such as reducing gas usage or temporarily substituting gas with coal can help manage short-term supply disruptions. However, these approaches are not without challenges, particularly the potential for higher carbon costs from a gas to coal switch. To address supply risks and cost pressures more sustainably, companies should focus on increasing their reliance on renewable energy, investing in solutions that enhance grid capacity, expanding biogas production and utilisation, and supporting domestic offshore gas projects. These strategies can provide structural resilience against volatile gas markets.

Gas demand down 20% since Russian gas crisis, but further cuts will be harder

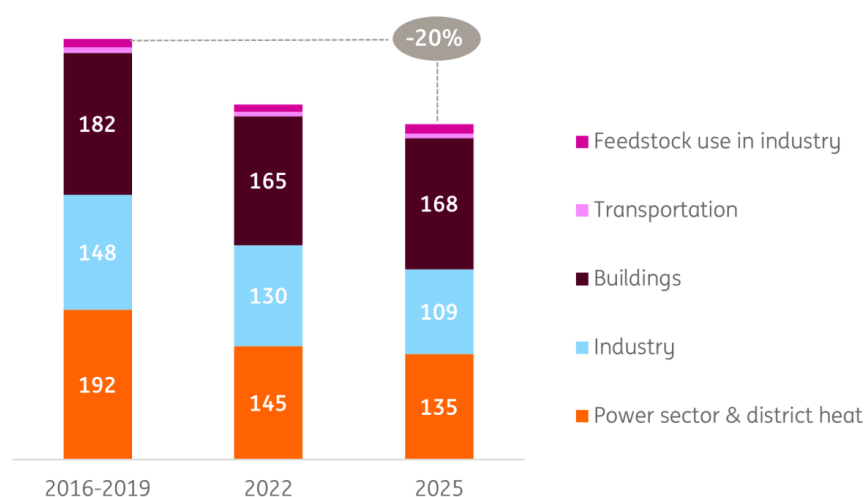
Since the 2022 energy crunch, European gas consumption has dropped from roughly 540 billion cubic meters (bcm) to 430 bcm, a notable reduction of 110 bcm, or 20%. Despite this progress, Europe still imports about 70% of its gas (just over 300 bcm annually), leaving it exposed to supply risks.

In the **building sector**, gas use has been structurally reduced by 8%, mainly due to conscious use (lower thermostats), better insulation, and increased adoption of heat pumps. The process of “greening” buildings is ongoing, but there are limited opportunities for rapid change.

Industry has seen gas consumption fall by 26%, but most of this has resulted from plant closures rather than efficiency gains. The chemical sector **lost** 37 million tons of gas and oil intensive refinery capacity due to shutdowns since 2022, while only seven megatons of new, “greener” capacity has been added, mostly in the battery, biobased, circular value chains and the modernisation of existing plants.

Gas use has been reduced by a fifth since the Russian energy crisis

Natural gas use in Europe (EU-27 + UK)



In the **power and district heating** sector, gas demand has dropped an impressive 30% compared to pre-crisis levels. Although electricity demand fell by just 3%, the power sector managed deeper gas reductions by shifting to renewables.

The question now is how much further Europe can reduce its dependence on imported gas and how that might affect businesses. This is not just an issue of compensation for high gas prices. It is about immediate, short-term measures that can quickly make a difference. We also examine longer-term solutions that could substantially reduce Europe's reliance on imported gas but require policy changes and sustained investments.

Gas diversification helped in 2022, but is tougher in today's multipolar world

At the onset of the Russia-Ukraine conflict, 40% of EU natural gas came from Russia, but by the end of 2025, this fell to 13%. While some countries were less reliant, Germany sourced over 55% of its gas from Russia before 2022, dropping to zero pipeline imports in 2025.

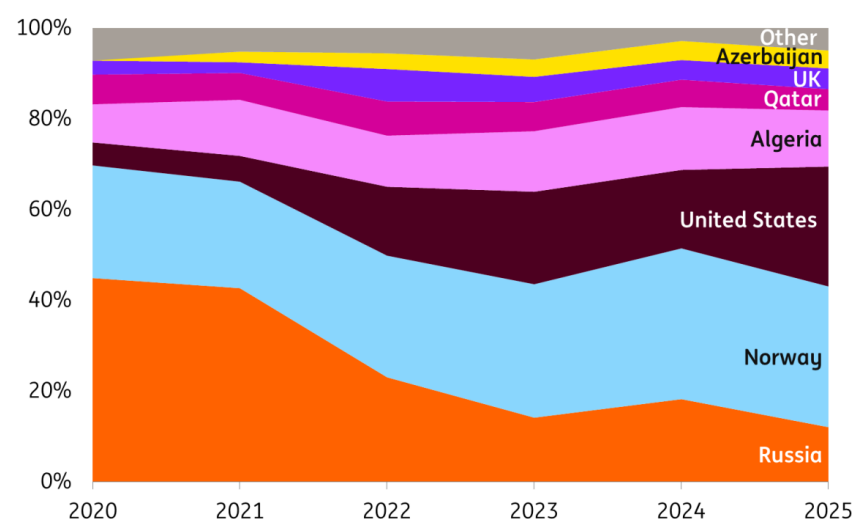
Norway is now the EU's top gas supplier, followed by the US

Norway is now the EU's top supplier (31% in 2025, up from 25% in 2020), followed by increased US

liquefied natural gas (LNG) (26%, up from 5%). Algeria increased its share to 12%. The UK and Qatar each provide nearly 5% of the EU's total gas imports, underscoring their continued but smaller role in the region's energy mix.

EU has shifted natural gas imports from Russia to Norway and the US

Gas imports to EU-27 per country of origin 2020-25 (based on volumes)



Source: ING Research based on Bruegel

Europe now relies on a wider range of suppliers, but paradoxically, the new geopolitical situation still leaves Europe vulnerable. If tensions with Russia escalate, Norwegian gas pipelines could face an increased risk of sabotage. And President Trump has used the threat of reduced LNG exports as leverage in trade negotiations, while exports from Azerbaijan and Algeria to the EU can only increase slightly and substantial growth would require new investments which impact gas flows only after 2030. Risk-free diversification is now less feasible than during the 2022 crisis.

Implications for business leaders

Most businesses rely on energy providers for their gas supply, but these providers have limited options to further diversify their procurement strategies. As a result, companies remain exposed to potential gas supply disruptions and the associated price volatility. To manage these risks, business leaders may employ hedging strategies, even when market prices are high, and often attempt to pass increased costs on to their customers.

Coal returns as an immediate but temporary solution

Coal remains the fastest option to replace natural gas in power generation, requiring no new capacity investments. After the Russian invasion of Ukraine, coal's share in Europe's power mix rose from 11% (2020) to 13% (2022).

Although some countries have closed their coal plants, significant capacity remains. In Germany, approximately 28 GW of coal-fired capacity is operational, including both hard coal and lignite units, with some scheduled to run beyond 2030. Poland retains around 27 GW of coal-fired power capacity and, as of mid-2025, has approved the extension of ageing 200 MW coal units for national security reasons. Meanwhile, the Netherlands is home to two of Europe's newest coal plants, with a combined capacity of 2.5 GW.

Until recently, gas-fired plants were more economically attractive than coal-fired plants, resulting in coal capacity being largely underutilised and readily available for rapid production increases. Given Europe's extensive and interconnected power grids, ramping up generation from coal plants could effectively reduce gas usage in power plants across the continent.

A common concern is the increase in carbon emissions. However, both coal and gas power plants operate under the EU Emissions Trading System (ETS), which sets a cap on total emissions regardless of the energy source. Switching to coal boosts demand for carbon allowances and, all else being equal, leads to higher prices for carbon allowance. Yet, in the event of a gas crisis, the additional carbon costs are typically much lower than the sharp rise in gas prices. This is already evident in current markets, where coal is increasingly used as a substitute for gas whenever gas prices surpass €45 per megawatt-hour.

Implications for business leaders

For business leaders, the implications are clear: while coal can provide a buffer against gas supply disruptions, it comes with the risk of increased carbon costs. The trajectory of ETS prices is influenced not only by greater coal usage but also by how much the gas crisis dampens economic activity, particularly in energy-intensive industries that drive demand for carbon allowances. When ETS prices rise, energy procurement costs increase, making exports to countries outside the EU less competitive. Consequently, investment strategies are shifting towards minimising both gas and carbon exposure – such as through energy efficiency initiatives and electrification – rather than depending on short-term fuel substitutions.

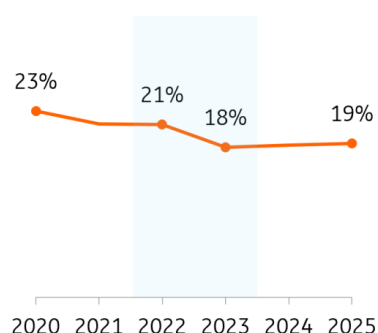
Renewables remain the long-term goal, but grid limits slow progress

During the 2022 energy crisis, lower gas use was largely offset by increased renewable generation while coal played a secondary role. This transition was further impacted by reduced output from hydropower and nuclear plants, which experienced operational disruptions from outages and severe droughts.

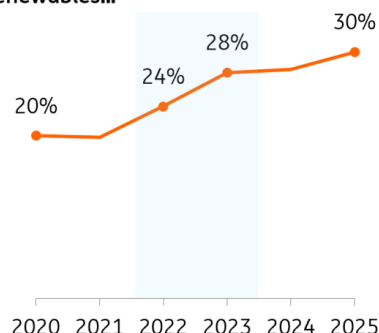
Within the power sector, renewable expansion replaced gas, with coal usage rising temporarily before resuming its decline

Share of energy source in European power generation mix (2020-2025)

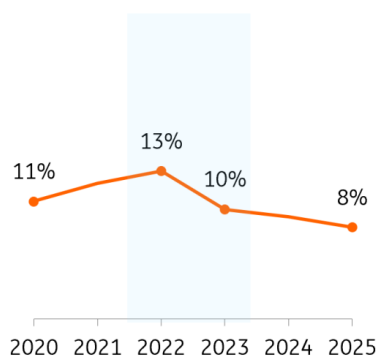
Reduction in gas dependence...



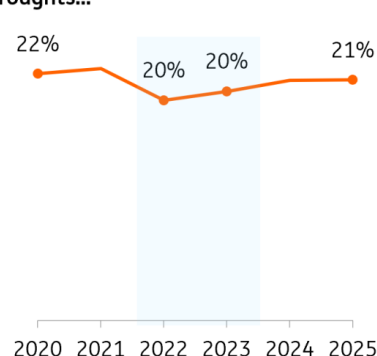
...was followed by a sharp increase in renewables...



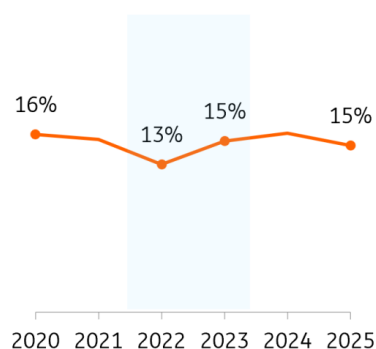
...and a short lived increase in coal...



...while hydropower was lower due to droughts...



...and nuclear power due to outages.



Source: ING Research based on Bloomberg New Energy Finance

According to DNV's 2026 global energy survey, 71% of senior energy professionals believe that expanding renewables is key to energy security. However, further expansion of renewables is now considerably more challenging compared to 2022 due to grid congestion. For example, in the Netherlands, more than 4,000 companies, including developers of wind and solar projects, are waiting for a grid connection. In Poland, 205 GW of renewable energy and storage projects are

queued for grid access.

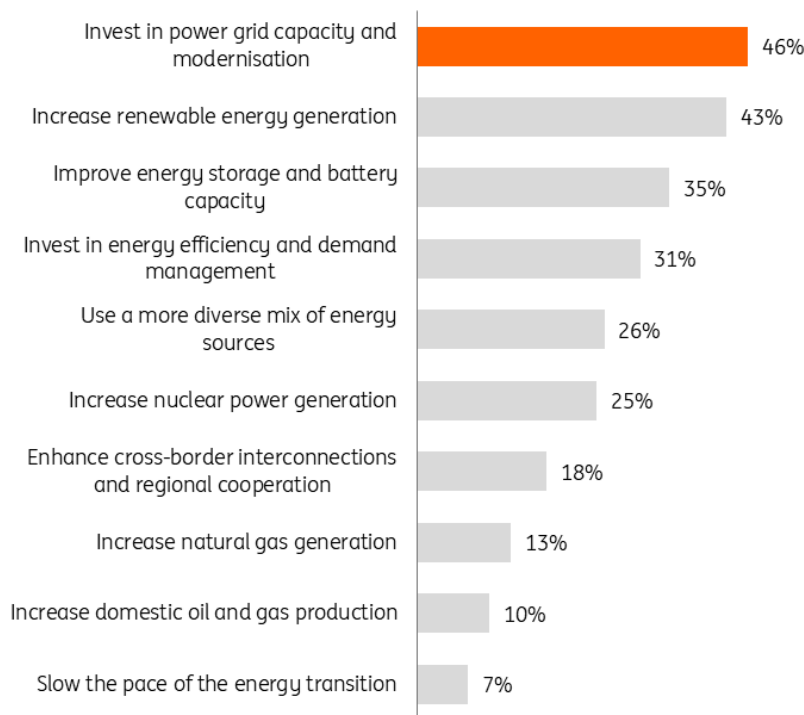
Grid congestion delays renewable expansion

Although speculative "ghost projects" inflate the numbers, real projects are affected. Since 1 January, Dutch grid operators now prioritise connections for grid-enhancing projects like batteries and demand flexibility, followed by critical needs (defence, hospitals, police, water), then societal services (housing, schools, waste, telecom). Businesses, including developers of renewables, are fast – often facing years-long delays.

So, while renewables are economically attractive, grid congestion delays expansion. Energy professionals now see grid investment as the most effective way to boost security.

What energy professionals think is the best way to improve energy security over the next three years

Percentage of respondents including the solution as one of their top three



Source: ING Research based on DNV's 2026 global energy survey

Implications for business leaders

For European businesses, renewables remain the cheapest and most credible route to reducing gas exposure and long term power costs. Politicians are also in favour of renewables – even more so in times of crisis – and they are likely to incentivise project developers to build renewables and businesses to use renewable electricity. However, for

business leaders, the constraint is no longer renewable economics, but infrastructure. The speed at which they can grow renewables will increasingly depend on access to grid capacity and flexibility solutions, making investments in storage, demand response, on site generation and locations with available grid headroom a strategic factor – rather than energy prices alone.

Biogas: Europe's scalable, local, and circular gas solution

Biogas stands out as a medium- and long-term solution for Europe, supporting a resilient system while reducing Europe's dependence on imported gas.

Europe produces about 7 billion cubic meters (bcm) of biogas (1.6% of demand). Forecasts by DNV and BNEF suggest production could triple to over 20 bcm by 2030 and plateau at 30 bcm by 2035 – almost 8% of current demand. While this is substantial growth, it falls short of the EU's 35 bcm REPowerEU target for 2030 that was defined in the wake of the Russian gas crisis.

Even more significantly, biogas has the theoretical capacity to supply up to one-third of Europe's current gas demand. This would require tapping into all available sustainable feedstocks, including manure, agricultural residues, organic waste, and utilising advanced gasification technologies. However, realising this potential depends on strong policy support, rapid technological deployment, and effective management of biomass competition – conditions that are currently far from being met.

In Denmark, biogas now supplies 40% of the country's gas demand

Denmark exemplifies biogas success, with 58 plants built in a decade now supplying 40% of national gas demand. With further policies, Denmark could reach 100% biomethane in a few years and even exceed domestic needs if it also pursues policies to reduce domestic gas demand. This would make Denmark's gas system net zero and locally circular, with renewables supplying electricity most of the time, and biogas providing backup at times when it is valued most. Biogas also helps agriculture by reducing manure and nitrogen emissions.

Biogas production costs currently range from €50 to €100 per megawatt-hour. Prior to the recent energy crisis, biogas was considered expensive, especially when compared to gas prices around €20 per megawatt-hour. This presents a difficult choice for both policymakers and business leaders: Should they prioritise the lowest-cost gas, risking increased exposure to volatile international markets, or pursue greater energy independence through locally produced, circular biogas at a higher cost? Historically, the preference has been for cheaper imported gas, but a renewed energy crisis could substantially strengthen the case for investing in biogas. Additionally, increased local biogas production means that Europe spends less on gas imports from countries outside the EU, keeping more of the economic benefits within its own borders.

Implications for business leaders

From a supply perspective, farmers and waste management companies have the ability to scale up biogas production, as long as the business case is attractive. Achieving this requires robust policy support and reliable buyers willing to pay a green premium for biogas. So, for business leaders on the offtake side, investing in biogas is not just about minimising costs; it's a strategic move to reduce exposure to volatile international energy markets and strengthen energy independence. Investing in higher priced, locally produced biogas can strengthen energy security, reduce carbon and import exposure, and keep value chains closer to home. As a result, competitiveness will increasingly depend on whether companies integrate energy resilience into investment decisions, rather than optimising solely for short term fuel costs.

Offshore gas: Europe's potential bridge as region shifts to low gas demand

Europe possesses significant offshore gas resources, with total reserves estimated at around 5,000 billion cubic meters (bcm), primarily located in Norwegian waters. Of this, approximately 2,000 bcm consists of proven (discovered) reserves, while the remaining 3,000 bcm represents potential reserves that could be uncovered through further exploration efforts.

Currently, production from offshore fields in the European Union, UK and Norway is set to fall from about 180 bcm per year today to about 30 bcm by mid-century. This is driven by the geological decline of existing production fields and the prevailing policy trajectory of one of 'managed decline'; gradually reducing production to align with net zero ambitions by 2050. For instance, in November 2025, the UK officially announced it would no longer grant new exploration licenses for offshore oil and gas exploration.

An alternative "maximum extraction and exploration" approach could slow this decline, making Europe less dependent on gas imports, while also reducing the carbon intensity of gas usage as North Sea gas emits up to six times less CO₂ than imported LNG from the US and Russia.

It's important to recognise that boosting offshore gas production alone does not shield Europe from high gas prices. As long as the region remains dependent on imported gas, liquefied natural gas (LNG) will continue to dictate market prices. This is why the most effective long-term solution is a comprehensive electrification strategy powered by renewables and nuclear energy, which breaks the link between electricity costs and gas prices. In the interim, increasing offshore gas output can help ease supply challenges, but it does not resolve Europe's vulnerability to global price fluctuations.

Implications for business leaders

For business leaders, there are two key takeaways. Firstly, while Europe possesses substantial gas reserves, current policy decisions mean these resources remain largely untapped. From a commercial standpoint, this is understandably difficult to accept, but unless a prolonged and severe gas crisis occurs, a significant policy reversal is unlikely. Secondly, even if offshore and biogas production are expanded, Europe will continue to face high and unpredictable gas prices as long as it remains dependent on global LNG markets.

This highlights the critical need to reduce direct exposure to gas by enhancing energy efficiency, accelerating electrification, and securing long-term power purchase agreements for electricity generated from renewable or nuclear sources.

Nuclear power revival: Europe's ambitious long-term strategy

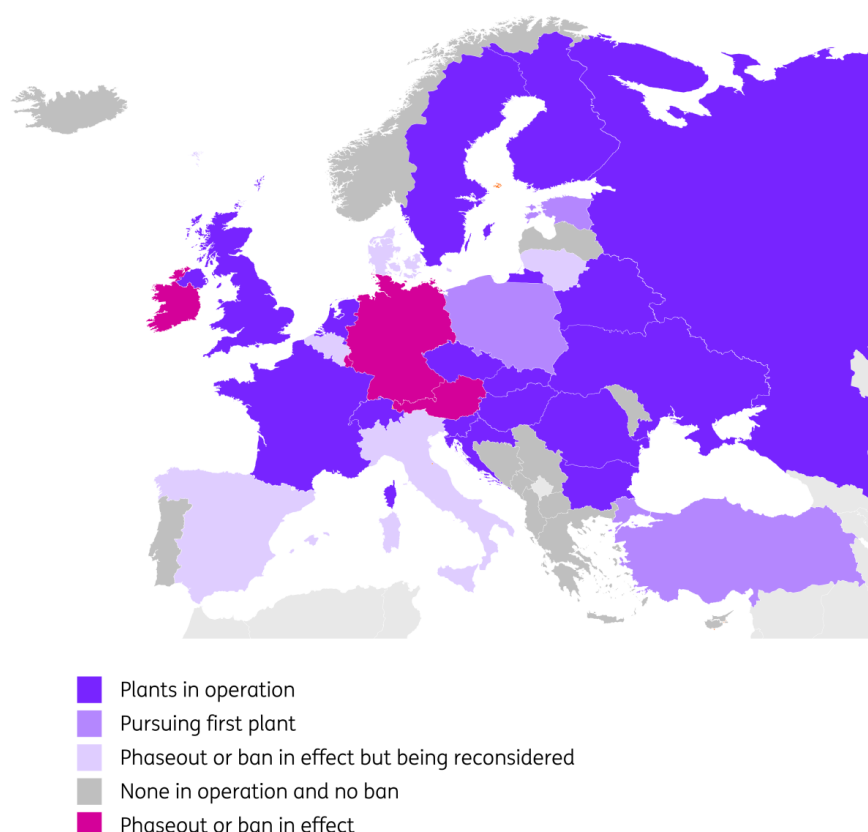
The 2022 energy crisis reignited interest in nuclear power throughout Europe, which could be further accelerated by today's crisis. Just like the 1973–74 oil crisis spurred France's large-scale nuclear buildout, which now supplies 70% of its electricity, ensuring reliability and low prices.

In March 2026, European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen publicly acknowledged that Europe's shift away from nuclear energy following the Fukushima disaster – most notably Germany's abrupt phase-out – was “a strategic mistake.”

Countries like Spain, Italy, Belgium, Denmark, and Lithuania are reconsidering nuclear bans. The UK made a final investment decision for the 3.3 GW Sizewell plant in 2025 while Hungary and Slovakia are building 1.7 GW of new capacity. And, according to the World Nuclear Association, 27 additional nuclear power plants are currently in the planning stages across the EU, underscoring a strong and growing commitment to nuclear power in Europe's future energy landscape.

Europe's evolving approach to nuclear power: some countries construct their first nuclear plants, others actively reconsider bans

Status of nuclear power in European power markets



Source: ING Research based on Bloomberg New Energy Finance

Extending the lifecycle of existing and low-cost nuclear power plants is a no regret policy. However, it is likely to take many years before Europe can significantly expand its nuclear power capacity, due to two key challenges.

First, recent attempts to build new nuclear plants in Europe have proven complex and costly. Flagship projects such as Flamanville, Olkiluoto, and Hinkley Point C have faced significant delays and substantial cost overruns, highlighting the considerable hurdles that remain for large-scale nuclear expansion.

Second, while interest in Small Modular Reactors (SMRs) is growing, their deployment is still in the early stages. At present, only two SMRs are operational – one in Russia and one in China – with two additional units under construction in Canada and the US. Furthermore, Europe faces heightened geopolitical risks with SMRs because these reactors rely on advanced nuclear fuel, which is primarily sourced from Russia. This dependence could complicate efforts to adopt SMR technology and increase vulnerability to supply disruptions.

So, despite the nuclear power revival, it is a long-shot strategy for Europe.

Therefore, while Europe is experiencing renewed interest in nuclear power, expanding its nuclear capacity remains a challenging and uncertain long-term endeavour.

Implications for business leaders

The revival of nuclear power in Europe has very different implications depending on where companies sit in the value chain. For business leaders operating in the nuclear value chain, especially those focused on innovation, engineering, design, fuel services, and project development, the evolving policy landscape offers clear support and new opportunities. Conversely, for energy-intensive industries, the outlook is more measured. For most companies, nuclear power remains a high-risk, long-term strategy rather than a practical solution, particularly if it diverts attention from existing technologies that can more readily decrease reliance on natural gas.

As Europe faces the prospect of another energy crisis, the solution should extend beyond simply lowering energy bills for households and businesses. There is an urgent need for technologies and policies that can significantly decrease Europe's future dependence on natural gas. As the energy crisis continues, we can expect significant progress in addressing grid congestion to accelerate renewable integration, ramping up biogas production, and potentially utilising temporary measures such as coal substitution or offshore gas extraction.

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The US tariff shock in 2025 vs 2026 – same negative impact, different drivers

The US tariff shock of 2025 was historic, but its impact on Europe was partly cushioned as tariffs on rival suppliers rose, keeping Europe's US market position broadly intact. Even so, exports fell amid higher tariffs and uncertainty. With tariffs converging to 15% in 2026 for most partners, Europe's competitiveness is set to deteriorate



One year on from the historic US tariff rollout, the impact is becoming clear

The rollout of new US tariffs in 2025 triggered months of uncertainty and market volatility. One year on, their impact is becoming clearer. Although the tariff hike was historical, its direct effect on the European economy proved more muted than initially feared. This not only reflected exemptions, tariff front-loading and strong US demand for pharmaceutical imports (especially from Ireland), but also the fact that US tariffs on many competing suppliers also rose sharply in 2025, temporarily preserving Europe's competitive position on the US market. Still, higher tariffs, the stronger euro, and heightened uncertainty weighed visibly on EU US trade.

Looking ahead, the drivers of EU-US trade are shifting. The Turnberry deal locks in a 15% tariff rate for EU exports, while tariffs on competing countries are also set to converge towards 15% in 2026. Countries such as China (31.1% effective tariff rate in 2025), India (20.5%) and Indonesia (20.8%) will therefore face substantially lower tariff rates than in 2025, eroding the EU's relative position on

the US market. As a result, the drag on EU exports is likely to persist, driven less by uncertainty and tariff asymmetries and more by a deterioration in relative competitiveness.

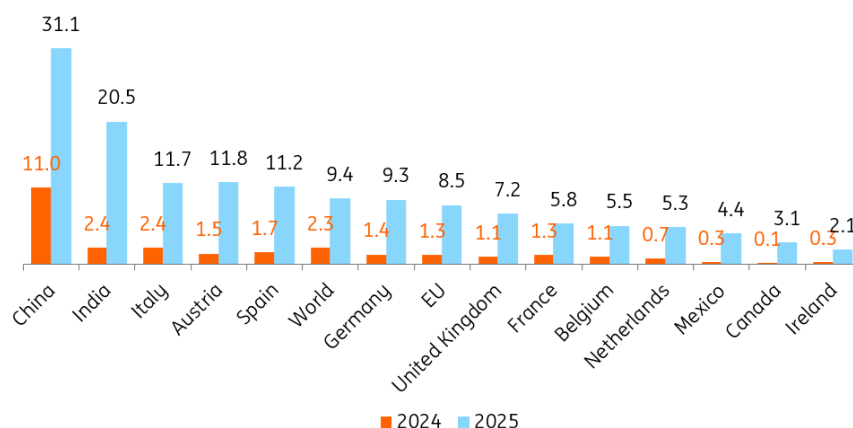
US tariffs jumped sharply in 2025, but less than feared

US tariffs increased sharply in 2025. The effective tariff rate rose by 8.1 percentage points, a historic jump, but one that ultimately proved less severe than the most adverse scenarios had anticipated. This more benign outcome partly reflected tariff stacking rules and sector specific exemptions, and partly the ability of exporters to adapt by rerouting trade flows or adjusting the composition of shipments to the US market.

For the EU, the effective tariff rate climbed to 8.5% in 2025, up by 7.2ppt compared with 2024. Despite the EU's common external tariff, effective tariff levels varied across countries due to different export structures and access to exemptions. As such, France, Belgium, and the Netherlands faced roughly half the effective tariff burden of countries such as Germany, Italy or Spain.

Large differences in effectively applied tariff rates, even within the European Union

US effective tariff rate, December values (%)



Source: US Census, ING Economic Research

EU-US exports in 2025: Tariff front-running, Irish outperformance and a sharp post-tariff decline

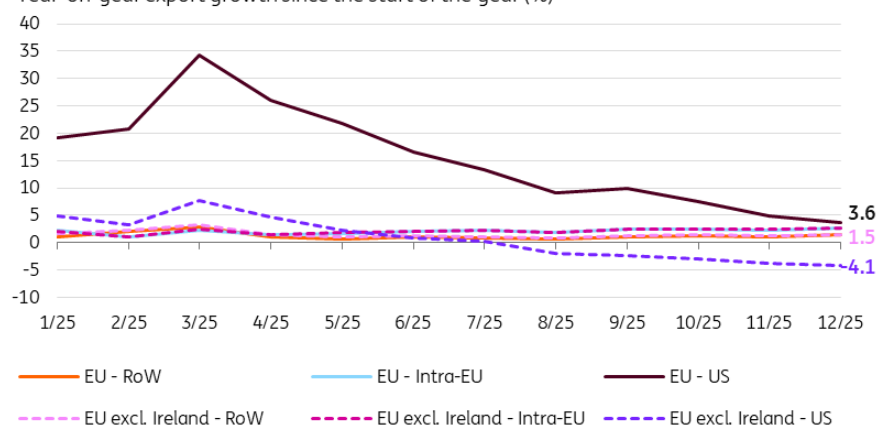
EU exports to the US followed a highly uneven pattern in 2025. Ahead of Liberation Day, exporters rushed shipments across the Atlantic in anticipation of higher tariffs, temporarily boosting exports by up to 35% year-on-year. This front loading effect was particularly pronounced in Ireland, where strong US demand for weight loss related pharmaceutical products largely offset the negative impact of tariffs throughout the year.

Once higher tariffs took effect, however, EU US trade weakened markedly. EU exports to the US, excluding Ireland, fell by 4.1% in 2025, despite exports to the rest of the world increasing by around 1.5% last year. This sharp difference suggests that the tariff shock had a strong negative impact on EU US trade, even if it was temporarily masked by front loading and Ireland specific factors, and broader macroeconomic developments like the strengthening of the euro.

EU exports to the US surged ahead of tariff hikes but fell markedly once higher tariffs took effect

EU export in 2025

Year-on-year export growth since the start of the year (%)



Source: Eurostat Comext, ING Economic Research

Tariff impact in 2025: Uncertainty amplifies the hit, competitiveness cushions the blow

Given these overlapping effects, what was the net impact of US tariffs on EU US trade in 2025? To answer this, we isolate and decompose the impact of US trade policy on EU trade into three channels using a regression framework.

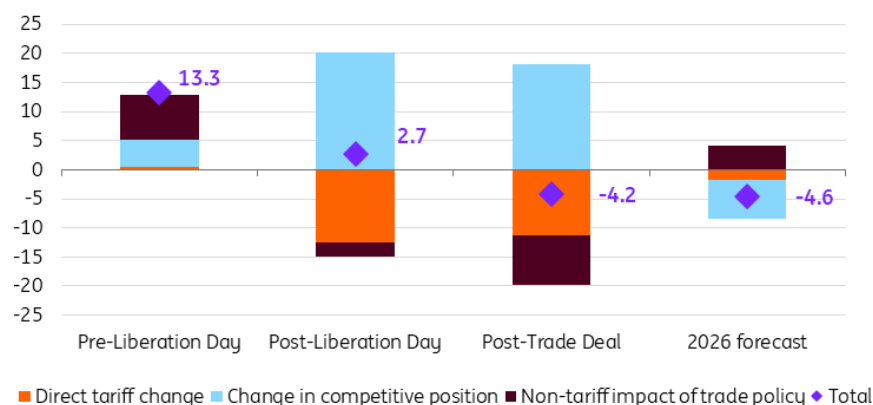
1. The **direct tariff effect** was immediate and sizeable. Following Liberation Day, higher tariffs triggered a strong fall in demand, depressing EU US trade.
2. This negative impact was more than offset by the sharp increase in **tariffs faced by competing suppliers** on the US market, such as China and India. As a result, the EU effectively regained ground relative to the direct tariff shock.
3. Tariffs also affected trade through **non tariff channels**. Heightened uncertainty initially encouraged tariff frontrunning, but later led to postponed investment and exports, as well as lower trade volumes due to rising administrative and compliance burdens.

Taken together, the direct tariff impact, shifts in relative competitiveness and uncertainty related effects point to a net reduction of around 4.2% in EU US exports in 2025. This estimate captures the pure impact of tariffs, abstracting from broader macroeconomic conditions. Yet, it aligns remarkably closely with the observed decline in EU exports to the US once the exceptional surge in Irish exports is excluded.

US tariffs are estimated to reduce EU↔US exports by more than 4% in both 2025 and 2026

Estimated impact of tariff changes in 2025 on European exports to the US

Year-on-year export growth since the start of the year (%)



Source: ING Economic Research Note: The estimated effects of tariff changes are derived from a gravity model of European exports at the sectoral level. The model uses effective US tariff rates and controls for general macroeconomic developments and other policy measures. The 2026 projection assumes the conclusion of a trade agreement between the EU and the US, leading to a slight increase in effectively paid tariffs, whose economic impact is assumed to strengthen gradually over time. At the same time, the projection assumes a decline in non-tariff barriers due to greater policy certainty and the global statutory tariff levels converging towards 15%.

More certainty, higher tariffs ahead

Against this backdrop, the endorsement of the Turnberry deal by the European Parliament marks a clear turning point in EU US trade relations (even if national ratification still has to follow). By ruling out the near term use of tariff coercion instruments, the agreement brings greater clarity and predictability. Fixing tariffs at 15% should reduce trade policy uncertainty and ease non tariff frictions, lowering compliance costs for firms exporting to the United States.

That clarity, however, comes at a price. Locking in a 15% tariff likely implies a higher effective tariff rate than the 8.5% observed in 2025. As a consequence, the EU's relative competitive position is set to weaken in 2026 as Europe's competitors in the US markets, like China, India, and Indonesia, will benefit relatively more from the US Supreme Court's ruling and the rollback of IEEPA related tariffs.

Taken together, higher tariffs and a deteriorating relative competitive position will outweigh the benefits of increased certainty in 2026. Unlike in early 2025, exporters can no longer rely on tariff frontrunning to cushion the impact. Moreover, as firms gradually adjust and substitution possibilities increase, trade responses will intensify. As a result, EU export growth to the US is expected to slow further by around 4.6% in 2026 due to tariffs alone, abstracting from broader macroeconomic developments, even though the underlying drivers differ from those observed in 2025.

Overall, the tariff shock may have been less dramatic than initially feared based on headline

numbers, but its economic damage is already evident and is likely to extend into 2026. Diversifying trade towards partners such as Mercosur and India is both a necessary and welcome policy response, but these markets still fall short of the depth of the US market. This reinforces the importance of strengthening the EU internal market as a key policy priority going forward.

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